

# CHANNEL-MATCH GUIDE

HOW THEY FIND OUT MATTERS AS MUCH AS WHAT YOU TELL THEM

|               | Urgent                                                                                                                                              | Not Urgent                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sensitive     | <b>Private and real-time, now.</b><br>A closed door, a call, a walk. Performance concerns, personal matters, anything that could embarrass someone. | <b>Private and real-time, scheduled.</b> Put it on the calendar as a one-on-one. Don't let "not urgent" become "never."                       |
| Not Sensitive | <b>Group and real-time.</b> A huddle, a call, a team channel ping. Outages, same-day changes, anything the whole team needs at once.                | <b>Async and written.</b> Email or a posted update. Policy changes, routine reminders, FYIs. Fast, efficient, and no one has to stop working. |

## THE ONE RULE THAT OVERRIDES THE REST

Sensitive always goes private and live. Urgency never justifies moving a sensitive conversation into writing or in front of the group. If it could embarrass someone, the channel is a closed door, every time.

## ONE MORNING, THREE CHANNELS

Three things hit your desk before ten o'clock:

- A system is down and a client demo is in an hour. Urgent, not sensitive. Team channel or a fast huddle.
- New expense codes take effect Monday. Routine, not sensitive. Async email.
- A teammate's work has slipped and something may be going on at home. Sensitive. Private, real-time, framed as a check-in rather than a correction.

Same morning, three messages, three channels. Sending any of them the wrong way creates a second problem on top of the first.

### Before a decision goes out:

Ask who this actually affects, and tell those people before the announcement does. A calendar invite is not how someone should learn their deliverable just got harder.

### If you get it wrong:

Name the miss, fix the immediate damage, then change the habit that caused it. "I should have checked with you before moving it. Let's find a time that works, and going forward I'll run schedule changes past the people they affect." An apology without a changed process just resets the same trap.